

COLLEGE OF ENGINEERING, UIC

CS 377 Ethical Issues in Computing (3 Credit Hours)

“Evil comes from a failure to think” —Hannah Arendt

Spring 2026

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Instructor & Course Details

Instructor: Jack Bandy (jxb@uic.edu)

Teaching assistants: TBD

Course site: doethics.fun

The current meeting times, room, office hours, teaching assistants, assignment deadlines, and grades are listed in Canvas.

Course Site

Canvas Course (canvas.uic.edu) - Students are expected to log in to Canvas regularly to learn about any developments related to the course, upload assignments, etc.

Public Website (doethics.fun) - Public site with reference materials for the course such as slides, assignment descriptions, ethical dilemmas, and more, are available on the course website. You are encouraged to edit the site and submit fixes/improvements in [Github](#).

Course Information

Catalog Course Description

CS 377. Ethical Issues in Computing. 3 hours.

Official catalog course description: Communication skills for computing professionals, including presentation organization, visual aids, delivery techniques, and argument support. Ethical and societal issues in computing include privacy, intellectual property and ownership, and crime.

Prerequisite: Credit or concurrent registration in CS 251.

Further information: [UIC Computer Science course catalog](#).

Dr. Bandy's Course Description

What does it mean for Computer Scientists to be socially responsible? Billions of people interact with computational systems every day for communication, amusement, work, and more. Although many interactions appear to happen seamlessly, even the most mundane human-computer interaction often has ethical implications related to privacy, climate, power, inequality, public health, and more. To explore these ethical implications, this course will survey classical perspectives of ethics (i.e. Deontological Ethics, Utilitarian Ethics, Virtue Ethics, Care Ethics) and practice using them to

interpret real-world situations involving humans and computers. Students will engage with recent scholarship about ethical issues in algorithmic decision-making, data management, user interface design, software engineering, search engines, algorithmic media feeds, large language models, and chatbots, to name some examples. Class sessions will promote active engagement through peer teaching, small group discussions, games, and more.

Learning Priorities

You are probably used to seeing concrete, specific “learning outcomes” for your math and CS classes. The outcomes for this class are more nebulous.

Namely, learning ethics is an ongoing practice. This class will therefore encourage you to continue discovering and practicing your values and your personal ethical commitments. In your other math and CS classes, you may eventually reach full expertise in a topic area, such as binary arithmetic. But you will not know everything there is to know about ethics just by completing this course.

Still, by the end of the course, students should be able to:

- explain fundamental professional responsibilities related to ethical, legal, security, and social issues in computing;
- analyze current events using virtue ethics, deontological ethics, utilitarian ethics, and care ethics;
- identify and describe recurring ethical challenges in the design and use of computing systems; and
- communicate ethical analyses clearly to different audiences.

Course requirement status: CS 377 is [required](#) for a BS in Computer Science at UIC

Topics overview: Classical ethical theories (Virtue, Deontological, Utilitarian, Care Ethics); algorithmic feeds and content moderation; privacy and contextual integrity; inequality and algorithmic fairness/bias; general cybersecurity; AI and large language models; intellectual property; environmental costs of computing.

Learning Materials

Readings and other materials will be provided through Canvas, printed copies, web archives, and/or linked PDFs.

There is no required textbook, however, the course draws heavily from *Computing and Technology Ethics: Engaging through Science Fiction* by Emanuelle Burton, Judy Goldsmith, Nicholas Mattei, Cory Siler, and Sara-Jo Swiatek.

Students will occasionally make their own selections of different research papers, news articles, case studies, books, and other materials to present and/or discuss in class.

Growth Mindset

Once again, unlike many other courses in the Computer Science department, the questions and problems discussed in this class often lack verifiable, complete, computable solutions. In many cases, there is no correct answer, nor even a consensus, to resolve ethical challenges.

For this reason as well as others, you may find course materials and exercises to be uniquely challenging. However, they are crucial to your intellectual and personal growth and development. There may be times when you need extra help or extra time to process materials in order to reach your own understanding of a concept. That is normal.

Any student can succeed if they attend class consistently, participate in discussions, complete exercises, thoughtfully engage with feedback (including feedback from the instructor, TAs, and peers), and contact the instructor when struggling. These habits will help you develop a thorough understanding of the course material and ultimately succeed in the course.

If we are indeed successful, by the end of the course, you will develop an understanding of your own values and the ethical reasoning behind them. This is useful not only for the course, and not only for your future career, but for your life in general.

Technology Outside Class

Students will need access to a web browser in order to use Canvas and the course website. This can be on your own laptop or a campus computer.

All exercises will be submitted and graded in Canvas.

Technology in the Classroom

I remember the frustration and shock I felt when I showed up to my first Computer Science course in college and learned that I was not allowed to use my computer. I have slowly realized that this policy was best for me as a student, and in most cases, is the best policy for

In Summer 2026, I looked at peer-reviewed scientific evidence on the subject. As with other times I have explored the evidence, my impression was that these **devices in the classroom are still detrimental for learning**, even when students feel accustomed to multitasking. Individual studies as well as meta-reviews continue to characterize devices in class as fundamentally distracting, with a negative influence on learning and performance.

Interestingly, while some students can multitask and still comprehend material *during* class time, those students experience significantly reduced long-term retention (Glass & Kang, 2019).

For these reasons, **by default, all class periods will be free from cell phones, laptops, and tablets**. In some cases, we will use devices for activities, usually for a few minutes at the end of class.

This policy is intended for your own benefit as well as the benefit of your classmates, as using a device often has a chain reaction of distracting other students.

You will be provided a notebook and/or paper for the course to take notes and write down questions that arise or factoids you wish to research after class. You are always encouraged to ask about factoids that you might otherwise look up on your device - someone in the class might know the answer, or at least have some insight!

Also, if you prefer to take notes on a device that can sit flat on the table, and you are confident that you can do this without distracting yourself and without distracting others, please come see me to make an arrangement.

Finally, **I will revisit the no-phone no-laptop policy with students throughout the semester**, and I remain open to revising the policy based on feedback / student needs.

In case you are curious, here is some of the evidence I looked at during Summer 2026 regarding in-class device distractions:

- Flanigan, Brady, Dai, & Ray (2023). Managing student digital distraction in the college classroom: A self-determination theory perspective. *Educational Psychology Review*. doi.org/10.1007/s10648-023-09780-y

- “...research has suggested that these digital distractions can negatively impact learning and performance.”
- Dontre (2021). The influence of technology on academic distraction: A review. *Human Behavior and Emerging Technologies*. doi.org/10.1002/hbe2.229
 - “The detrimental effects of student smartphone and social media use on academic distraction are more conspicuous, especially with the pervasiveness of personal digital devices.”
- Martin, Long, Haywood, & Xie (2025). Digital distractions in education: A systematic review of research on causes, consequences and prevention strategies. *Educational Technology Research and Development*. doi.org/10.1007/s11423-025-10550-6
 - “Consequences for digital distraction included personal performance issues (66.67%), ineffective classroom instruction (23.33%), and problematic technology use (10%).”
- Wang, Tigelaar, Zhou, & Admiraal (2023). The effects of mobile technology usage on cognitive, affective, and behavioural learning outcomes in primary and secondary education: A systematic review with meta-analysis. *Journal of Computer Assisted Learning*. doi.org/10.1111/jcal.12759
 - Notably, this review found that *structured, instructor-directed* technology use can help: “using mobile technology produced medium positive and statistically significant effects on primary and secondary students’ learning.”
- Sana, Weston, & Cepeda (2013). Laptop multitasking hinders classroom learning for both users and nearby peers. *Computers & Education*. doi.org/10.1016/j.compedu.2012.10.003
 - “...multitasking on a laptop poses a significant distraction to both users and fellow students and can be detrimental to comprehension of lecture content.”

Course Policies & Classroom Expectations

Assessment

This class aims to use principles of student-centered teaching, also referred to as “non-directive teaching,” which de-emphasizes quantitative grading. This teaching style focuses on open-ended dialogue, project-based learning, and student curiosity, rather than regurgitation and examinations. Still, in order to provide a final letter grade at the end of the class, I will use the following combination of exercises:

Category	Weight
Out-of-class exercises	20%
<i>Food in your feed</i>	
<i>Online account biopsy</i>	
<i>Online account scrap doll</i>	
<i>Speculative fiction</i>	
<i>Fairness definition</i>	
<i>Personal ethical commitment</i>	
“Read a Book” project	20%
<i>Book selection and justification</i>	
<i>2-page book report or un-essay</i>	

Category	Weight
<i>Peer instruction / book presentation</i>	
<i>Actually reading the book</i>	
In-class group exercises	20%
<i>Expect about one per week</i>	
Pre-class reflections	20%
<i>Expect about one per week</i>	
Attendance, participation, and civility	20%

Final grades use the following scale: A = 90–100%, B = 80–89%, C = 70–79%, D = 60–69%, and F = below 60%.

You can expect the following correspondence between your percentage grade in the course and your final letter grade, and the “equivalent” description from the registrar.

F	D	C	B	A
59% or below	60–69%	70–79%	80–89%	90–100%
Failure	Poor but passing	Average	Good	Excellent

Tests

There will be no tests or examinations in this class. I agree with Carl Rogers¹ that life itself offers enough examinations, and I hope that what you learn in this class will help you meet life’s tests with more confidence and satisfaction. See above for details regarding your final grade.

Attendance and Participation

Showing up makes a substantial difference in this course (and in life). Class meetings are designed around discussion and group work, so students should attend, arrive on time, and participate. Notify the instructor as soon as possible when illness, personal emergencies, university obligations, religious observances, or other circumstances may prevent attendance.

I take attendance each class. Three absences may be taken without penalty. If a student misses more than three classes without notifying the instructor...

Students who miss more than half of all class sessions will not be able to pass the course.

I will keep attendance on paper via roll call this semester and note any absences in Canvas. If you miss a fourth class without notifying the instructor, you will be contacted by the instructor.

The semester at UIC is fifteen weeks long, and we meet Mondays and Wednesdays...

Late Work

Due dates will be listed in Canvas, and there is an automatic “sliding scale” that will deduct points based on how late you submitted the work, down to 50%.

¹*On Becoming a Person*, Chapter 14

Anything submitted more than one week after the original due date will only receive 50% credit. If you anticipate any difficulty meeting a due date, contact the instructor as soon as possible.

Academic Integrity

Students are expected to follow UIC's [Community Standards](#) and policies on [academic integrity](#).

Although I try to use open materials (i.e. public domain, Creative Commons, etc.), please help protect copyright integrity when appropriate, namely for materials distributed through Canvas.

In line with UIC's mission to provide "an environment in which research, learning, and scholarship can flourish and in which all endeavors are guided by academic and professional integrity," **the work you turn in for this class must be your own work.**

This is to ensure that **you** develop skills and knowledge from this course that will be valuable to you in your future courses, your career, and other areas of your life.

This does not mean that you need to complete all work in a bunker. Rather, you are encouraged to discuss your ideas with friends and classmates, and to explore related work (i.e. academic papers, blogs, video essays, forums, etc.). An important part of scholarship is standing on the shoulders of giants,² (after all, we are in the City of the Big Shoulders³) and acknowledging whose shoulders we stand upon. In other words, **cite your sources!**

Please ask the instructor if you need clarity about academic integrity for specific exercises. When in doubt, it is always better to check with the instructor before proceeding.

I will reach out to you personally before submitting a report of academic misconduct.

TODO: AI specifics.

Visitors

This class may welcome visitors (i.e. prospective students, guest speakers, etc.) during the semester. When possible, students will be notified in advance of guest attendance.

Email Expectations

Students are responsible for all messages sent to your UIC email and Canvas accounts.

While I do not closely monitor my email on Saturdays and Sundays, during the week, I generally aim to respond to emails within 24 hours.

Approximate Course Schedule

The detailed and most current schedule will be published on the "[do ethics](#)" website. We may revise readings, activities, or due dates as course needs develop. Any changes will be announced in class and updated in Canvas.

²Ironically, while this phrase is often attributed to Isaac Newton in a letter from 1676, it was first recorded in John of Salisbury's book *Metalogicon* from 1159. I learned this from a blog post on BookBrowse.com

³Sandburg, Carl. "Chicago." *Poetry* (March 1914).

Week	Topic(s) / In-Class Activities	Readings / Work Due
1	Warm-up activity; intro to Virtue Ethics	
2	MLK Day (no class); intro to Deontological Ethics	Virtue Ethics Reflection
3	Intro to Utilitarian Ethics and trolley problems; intro to Care Ethics	Reflection(s)
4	Ethical theory review and case studies; Ethics in Algorithmic Feeds	Care Ethics Reflection; Select a Book; Food in your Feed; Ranking Exercise
5	Algorithmic feeds; intro to Privacy and contextual integrity	In-class Privacy Policy Exercise
6	Privacy and short story analysis; Dr. Bandy at SIGCSE	Here-and-Now Reflection; Online Account Biopsy
7	Inequality, Justice, algorithmic fairness	Message in a Bottle Reflection; Online Account Scrap Doll
8	Cybersecurity; medical and health technologies in AI	Speculative Fiction
9	LLM ethical challenges	Reflection(s)
10	Intellectual property	Fairness Definitions
11	<i>Spring Vacation — No Classes</i>	
12	Environmental computing impact; book presentations begin	Reflection(s)
13	Book presentations	
14	Book presentations	
15	Book presentations	Personal Ethics Commitments
16	Synthesis and conclusions	Book Report/Un-essay, Presentation

Another Disclaimer

This syllabus is intended to give the student guidance on what may be covered during the semester and will be followed as closely as possible. However, again, we might decide to alter this syllabus as course needs arise, and I will communicate such changes through in-class announcements and in writing via Canvas and/or email.

Accommodations

Disability Accommodation Procedures

UIC is committed to full inclusion and participation of people with disabilities. Students who face or anticipate disability-related barriers should contact the [Disability Resource Center](#) at drc@uic.edu or (312) 413-2183. Upon receipt of a Letter of Accommodation, the instructor will work with the student and DRC to implement approved accommodations.

Religious Accommodations

Students seeking religious accommodations should notify the instructor by the tenth day of the semester, or at least five days in advance when the observance occurs earlier. Please submit this form by email with the subject heading: "YOUR NAME: Requesting Religious Accommodation."

Classroom Environment

Classroom Community

Every member of the class is expected to contribute to a respectful, welcoming, and inclusive environment. Assume goodwill, listen carefully, debate ideas rather than people, respect privacy, and remain open to revising your position.

Preferred Names and Pronouns

If your name or pronouns do not match the class roster, please let the class know so that we can address you the way you want to be addressed. I use he/him pronouns. For more information, see: <https://www.mypronouns.org/what-and-why>.

Guidelines for Participation and Classroom Conduct

Active participation is one of the most important ways you will learn in this course. I am very aware that participation looks a little different for everyone, and will evaluate your participation accordingly. Still, in general, an engaged student will:

- come to class prepared, for example, by having completed pre-class reflections
- contribute regularly to class activities and discussions
- stay on-task during class
- listen attentively to peers (no side conversations or unnecessary disruptions)
- have an open mind and seek to understand (not judge and make assumptions)
- be gracious and open to change in their ideas, arguments, and positions
- assume goodwill in all interactions, even in disagreement
- complete their work in a timely manner
- reach out to the instructor if they start to fall behind

Content Notices

This is a 300-level University course, and some course materials address war, discrimination, surveillance, sex, violence, and related subjects which may be distressing. We will aim to discuss these topics with dignity, humanity, rigor, and respect for scholarly inquiry.

Our classroom provides a space for civil exchange of ideas, which intentionally includes a variety of perspectives and positions. Some readings and other content may expose you to ideas, subjects, or views that may challenge you, cause you discomfort, or recall past negative experiences or traumas. I try to include content notices whenever appropriate. If you have suggested changes, or you would like me to be aware of a specific topic of concern, please email or visit me during office hours.

Resources: Academic Success, Wellness, and Safety

Student Wellbeing

As a student at UIC, I hope you have come to enjoy the learning process and the life of the mind, and I hope you enjoy this particular course. I also understand that life as a college student can sometimes become distressing and overwhelming, which can make it difficult to engage in class.

So, to help you succeed in this course (and in life), I encourage you to proactively care for your body and mind. If you are struggling or anticipate any trouble attending class or turning in assignments on time, **please let me know as early as possible** and I will do whatever I can to help you prioritize your wellbeing.

Below are some of the many support services and resources available to all UIC students:

- Current Student Resources – a one-stop shop for links to resources in the following categories: General, Academic, Student Support, Student Life, Technology, Health and Safety, and Getting Around Campus
- UIC Tutoring Resources
- UIC College of Engineering Tutoring Program
- The First-at-LAS academic success program for first-generation students
- Programs and initiatives supporting the UIC undergraduate experience and academic programs through the Student Success Initiative
- If you are experiencing personal hardships (e.g. personal and family emergencies, academics, interpersonal conflicts, personal safety, physical and mental health concerns, food or housing insecurity) and need resources and assistance, please reach out to the Student Assistance division
- Student Guide for Information Technology – a comprehensive resource for UIC students describing the most commonly used IT services and tools supporting your success
- Navigating Health Resources at UIC – explore the many resources that are on campus to support students' health and wellbeing and learn about how you can access them.

Importantly, **if you are in immediate distress**, please know the UIC Counseling Center provides high-quality crisis intervention services, available 24 hours a day, 7 days a week. You can walk into the Counseling Center during business hours to request to talk to a crisis counselor, or you can call the Counseling Center main line at (312) 996-3490. If you are calling outside of business hours, select “2” during the automated greeting to be connected to a crisis counselor. You can find additional mental health resources and services on the Counseling Center Website and the Student’s Guide to Accessing Behavioral Health Services at UIC.

For immediate crisis support outside of UIC, call or text “9-8-8” any time, 24 hours a day, 7 days a week. Dialing 988 will connect you to a trained crisis professional. 988 offers services in Spanish, American Sign Language, and over 240 languages through tele-interpretation services. The 988 website has an online chat feature, too.

We all need the help and the support of our UIC community. Please visit my office hours for course consultation and other academic or research topics. For additional assistance, please contact your assigned college advisor and visit the support services available to all UIC students.

Academic Success

- Equity and Inclusion in Engineering Program
- UIC Library and UIC Library Research Guides
- Offices supporting the UIC undergraduate experience and academic programs

Wellness

- Access U&I Care Program for assistance with personal hardships
- Campus Advocacy Network (Title IX): TitleIX@uic.edu and <http://can.uic.edu/>

Safety

- UIC Safe App (please download for your safety)
- UIC Safety Tips and Resources
- Night Ride
- Emergency: Dial 5-5555 from a campus phone, or (312) 355-5555 from a cell phone

*The following are mostly boilerplate blurbs from our Academic Center for Excellence (ACE).*⁴

Support for Parenting Students

UIC supports parenting students by providing affordable, high-quality childcare for infants, toddlers, and young children, along with a comprehensive wraparound care system, study-play areas across campus, accessible lactation rooms, year-round family events, and more. For more information, contact Melinda Young (mmcghe2@uic.edu) or visit the [Little Sparks website](#).

The Writing Center offers friendly and supportive tutors who can help you with reading and writing in any of your courses, not just English. Tutors are ready to help with other writing as well, such as job applications, personal statements, and resumes. The tutor and you will work together to decide how to improve your writing. If you have not started your assignment, that is OK. A tutor can help you brainstorm or make an outline. Tutors understand that you might be using the Writing Center for the first time. They are ready to guide you through your first session. You can choose to work with a tutor in person or in real time over the internet using video, audio, or chat and a whiteboard. For more information and to schedule an appointment, visit the Writing Center website.

The Math and Science Learning Center, located in the Science and Engineering South Building (SES) at 845 W. Taylor St. 3rd Floor, Room 247, is a meeting place for students in Math, Biological Sciences, Chemistry, Earth and Environmental Sciences, and Physics. At the MSLC, students can meet with graduate teaching assistants for tutoring in 100-level courses, attend informal group study

⁴<https://teaching.uic.edu/cate-teaching-guides/syllabus-course-design/syllabus/>

sessions with other students, or meet up with friends to attend one of the workshops, seminars, or other activities sponsored by the MSLC during the semester. Visit the MSLC website, call 312-355-4900, or email at mslc@uic.edu.

The Academic Center for Excellence (ACE) can help if you feel you need more individualized instruction in reading and/or writing, study skills, time management, etc. Please call (312) 413-0031 or visit the Academic Center for Excellence (ACE) website for more information.

Emergency response guides can be found at the Office of Preparedness and Response. Please review and acquaint yourself with the guide and recommendations for various emergency situations.

Student Health Services are available if you get sick during the semester. The Family Medicine Center is committed to providing high-quality, student centered care and services. It has attending physicians, residents, and nurse practitioners on staff to provide the full range of primary health care services. The Family Medicine Center also offers a limited set of health services at no additional cost to students who pay the Student Health Service Fee (SHSF). Services include caring for an acute or urgent illness (e.g., cold, strep throat, asthma attack, flu) or an injury. More information can be found on the Family Medicine Center's Student Health webpage.

Lastly, here is a picture of Hannah Arendt. She said that “evil comes from a failure to think.” If we are successful in this class, we will do some real thinking, and perhaps prevent some evil.



Hannah Arendt, photographed on New Year's Day, 1944. © Fred Stein/dpa/Corbis